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Initial **mo-* in Latin and Italic

1. Introductory

1.1. From the perspective of Proto-Indo-European, it is a truism to observe that there is "too much" *a*-vocalism in Italic.[1] Scores of forms in Latin (and elsewhere in Italic) display an *a*-vocalism that does not match *e*- or *o*-vocalism elsewhere, as the following simple contrasts illustrate:

(i) Gk. δοτός 'given', but Lat. *datus*
(ii) Gk. πετάννυμι 'spread', but Lat. *pandere* (< **pat(V)ne/o-,* cf. O. **patensíns**)
(iii) Gk. κο(ϝ)έω 'perceive', but Lat. *cavēre* 'beware'
(iv) Gk. μέγας 'great, large', but Lat. *magnus*
(v) Ved. *cand-* (*ca-* < **ke-*) 'bright', but Lat. *candēre, candidus*
(vi) OIr. *loch* 'lake', but Lat. *lacus*
(vii) Go. *wadi,* Li. *vãdas* (**u̯od^{h}-*) 'bail', but Lat. *vas* (gen. *vadis*)
(viii) OIc. *hvalr* 'whale', OPr. *kalis* 'catfish' (**k^{w}ol-*), but Lat. *squalus* 'seal'
(ix) OIr. *muir* 'sea' (**mor-i-*), but Lat. *mare*

We now, of course, have good explanations for many of these cases, largely as a result of significant phonological insights from post-Neogrammarian times. Thus item (i) arises from a basic tenet of laryngeal theory, according to which interconsonantal laryngeals "vocalize" as /a/ in Italic (**dh$_3$-tó-* > Gk. δοτός, Lat. *datus* regularly).[2] Item (ii), similarly, results from the Italic *a*-epenthesis of "schwa secundum", in certain initial clusters: thus **p$_e$tnV-* > Lat. *pandere,* O. **patensíns** regularly, for which the proper comparandum is not Gk. πετάννυμι (with secondary full grade), but

[1] Schrijver (1991:420-4) provides a useful survey of the problem.
[2] See, e.g., Meiser 1998:107, Weiss 2009:50, 96.

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rather the nasal present *p_etneh_2- > Gk. πίτνημι (with zero-grade of the root, and thus its own schwa-secundum reflex).[3] Yet another phonological insight explains item (iii): the process known as "Thurneysen-Havet's Law" (roughly *$o\underline{u}V$ > Ital. /a$\underline{u}$V/) directly accounts for the development of PIE *$ko\underline{u}H$-$é\underline{i}e/o$- to Lat. *cavēre* (beside Gk. κο(ϝ)έω).[4]

Nevertheless, we are left with a substantial residue: how are we to explain the *a*-vocalism in the many forms belonging to the types illustrated by items (iv) through (ix) above?

1.2. The problem just sketched poses a particularly acute conundrum for adherents of the "Leiden School" gospel, which categorically denies the existence of PIE *a.[5] It is not surprising, then, that the Leiden-trained scholar Peter Schrijver has made the most significant contributions to the problem, in his magisterial book *The Reflexes of the Proto-Indo-European Laryngeals in Latin* (1991). Schrijver offered many new proposals for explaining both laryngeal and non-laryngeal *a*-vocalism — all of them, including the non-laryngeal cases, without recourse to a PIE vowel *a. To restrict ourselves to the non-laryngeal side of the problem: some of these proposals, even if not universally accepted, seem very attractive. Thus for forms like Lat. *magnus* (item (iv) above), Schrijver proposes (1991:477-85) a phonological rule according to which *a*-vocalism develops regularly between syllabic liquid and voiced stop, when another consonant follows (i.e., $\underset{\circ}{R}DC > RaDC$).[6] Other proposals have met with more resistance. Thus for item (v) above, Schrijver sought to show (1991:425-35) that while PIE *$\hat{k}e$- (with palatal) yields Ital. /ke-/ (with *e*-vocalism retained), PIE *ke- (with pure velar) develops regularly to Ital. /ka-/. This is a bold theory, with somewhat extreme consequences, including a new conception of Italic as a "semi-satem" language. Some of Schrijver's examples are

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3 See, e.g., Meiser 1998:171, Weiss 2009:36.

4 See Vine 2006, with earlier references.

5 Foundational treatments include Lubotsky 1989, Beekes 1995:124f., 138f., explicitly followed in much recent work; most relevant here is de Vaan 2008:6 (and passim).

6 The rule is accepted by Meiser (1998:65) and acknowledged as an alternative possibility by Weiss (2009:81n10).

suggestive, but there are also a number of serious counterexamples; thus, while occasional adherents can still be found,[7] strong reservations were immediately expressed by Rasmussen (1993:199f.), the rule has been rejected by Meiser (1998:82f., with discussion of the counterexamples), and has now been abandoned even by de Vaan (2008 passim, see most explicitly 2008:541, s.v. *scabō*).

Finally, items (vi) through (ix) form a coherent group: these belong to a series of proposed phonological rules of the type **Co-* > Ital. /Ca-/ in initial syllables, described as unrounding processes that can be ascribed to "labial dissimilation" (descriptively similar, therefore, to Thurneysen-Havet's Law, cf. **1.1** above). More specifically:

(vi) PIE **lo-* > Ital. /la-/ (Schrijver 1991:475-6)[8]
(vii) PIE **u̯o-* > Ital. /u̯a-/ (Schrijver 1991:460-75)
(viii) PIE **C^{w}o-* > Ital. /C^{w}a-/ (also **Cu̯o-* > /Cu̯a-/) (ibid.)
(ix) PIE **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/ (Schrijver 1991:454-75)

Each of these proposals deserves careful consideration. Here I address only the last: it is now regularly invoked as established fact by Leiden School scholars,[9] and has received sympathetic assessments not only by Rasmussen (1993:200f.) and Rix (1996:162) in their reviews of Schrijver's book, but also by Meiser in his handbook of Latin historical-comparative grammar (1998:84f.).[10] Reservations have nevertheless been expressed by Katz (1998:213 n. 85, 2006:339f.), though without extended discussion. My proposal here is that Katz's reservations are fully justified, and more specifically that for initial **mo-* in open syllables — which characterizes most of the PIE **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/ data invoked by Schrijver — all relevant forms are better analyzed in entirely different ways. In contrast, Schrijver's conception may be more attractive for initial **mo-* in (certain restricted types of) closed syllables.

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7 The rule is apparently accepted by Garnier (2010:422).

8 For the conception of this process in terms of "labial dissimilation": compare the development of initial **lV-* to /u̯V-/ in Umbrian and South Picene.

9 E.g., Driessen 2001:56, de Vaan 2008:8 and passim.

10 The proposal is acknowledged, without discussion, by Weiss (2009:141n28), in his recent handbook.

2. PIE **mo-* > Ital. **ma-* in initial open syllables

2.1. Lat. *mare* 'sea'

In striking contrast to the *o*-vocalism of PIE **mór-i-* (OIr. *muir,* OCS *morje,* Go. *marei*, etc.), Lat. *mare* 'sea' [Liv. Andr.+], with its *a*-vocalism, constitutes a Paradebeispiel for Schrijver's proposed sound law PIE **mo-* > Ital. **ma-* (1991:459, 474, followed by de Vaan 2008:365, s.v.). The traditional alternative, to be sure, is not satisfactory: according to a theory popularized by Kuryłowicz (especially 1956), *a*-vocalism of this kind is "explained" by appeals to "secondary zero grades" (or "zero grade replacements", "reduced grades", etc.),[11] and versions of this approach continue to be promulgated.[12] But without further specification, this vague and unconstrained concept has little value.

A much better account of *mare* has been proposed by Nussbaum (2004a).[13] He begins with the assumption of original acrostatic inflection (neut. nom. sg. **mór-i*), and further the well-established pattern whereby acrostatic nouns (particularly those with root shape *CER(H)-*) are remodeled with "pseudo- (or neo-) proterokinetic" oblique forms: cf. Ved. nom. sg. *dā́ru* (acrostatic **dór-u*), but gen. sg. *dróḥ* ("neo-proterokinetic" **dr-éu̯-s*) 'wood'. For **mór-i*: monosyllabic "neo-proterokinetic" oblique forms such as gen. sg. **mr-és*[14], dat. sg. **mr-éi̯*[15] would have been resyllabified as disyllabic **mr̥(r)-és, *mr̥(r)-éi̯* (see further **2.5** below on the resyllabification). The central claim, then, is that the regular result of

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11 See again Schrijver's valuable survey and critique of such approaches (1991: 420ff.).

12 See in general Rasmussen 1990/91; several more recent instances will be cited along with individual forms below.

13 Recent adherents include Nikolaev (2004:327 n. 3) and Weiss (2009:105, 314).

14 I.e., following the early replacement of "ideal" *i*-stem gen. sg. **-ei̯-s* (or **-i-s* or **-i̯-es*) with consonant-stem **-es.*

15 I.e., following the very early haplological reduction of original *i*-stem dat. **-ei̯-ei̯* to **-ei̯* (Klingenschmitt 1992:105, Weiss 2009:244f.).

such resyllabified sequences *R̥(R)V-* (for R = /r, l, n/) is /aRV-/.[16] All that remains is the natural assumption that paradigmatic leveling would apply to **mori, *mares, *marei*, etc. to yield *mare, maris, marī,* etc. (with generalized *a*-vocalism).

The broader claim (and the main thrust of the present contribution) is that the essential features of this analysis are applicable to nearly all of the other alleged instances of PIE **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/.

2.2. Lat. *marītus* (m.) 'husband', (adj.) 'wedded, nuptial'

According to Schrijver (1991:459f.), Lat. *marītus* derives from a **morī-to-*, comparable in particular to the *i*-stem **mori-* in Celtic **mori-gnā* (W. *morwyn* 'maiden', OCo. *moroin*). But this leaves the morphology of *marītus* entirely unaccounted for; indeed, Schrijver himself observes that "[i]ts formation is opaque". The assertion that *marītus* shows "[d]erivation with possessive **-to-* from a stem **morei-/*morī-*" (de Vaan 2008:365, s.v.) is little more than a descriptive observation (again with the assumption of PIE **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/), leaving unexplained the decidedly odd alternation in the "stem **morei-/*morī-*".

We may begin by noting that beside the forms with *o*-vocalism (which also include Li. *martì* 'girl, young bride'), a significant part of the morphological profile for this word involves *e*-grade material, as in MW *merch* 'girl, daughter' (< **mer-k-*, beside the *o*-grades in *morwyn,* OCo. *moroin,* above); Li. *mergà* 'girl', OPr. *mergo, -u, -a* 'maiden' (< **mer-g^h-*); and Gk. μεῖραξ 'young girl', μειράκιον 'lad' (both based ultimately on a **mer-i̯-o-*).[17] This suggests, once again, an original (in this case animate)

[16] I return below (**2.5**) to the sequence **m̥(m)V-*, and more generally to the question of alternative views concerning the treatment of *N̥(N)V-* sequences in Italic.

[17] The root vocalism is ambiguous in the corresponding IIr. form seen in Ved. *márya-* 'young man', YAv. *mairiia-* 'scoundrel' (< **mEr-i̯-o-*). For this material, see recently Janda 2006:185 (with a root etymology based on **mer-* 'disappear, die') and Pinault 2008:156 (with a different morphological analysis, i.e. **már-ya-* 'garçon, jeune homme' as a "dérivé individualisant" vis-à-vis **mar-út-* 'groupe de jeunes garçons'; but this is, of course, only one of several possible versions of the background of Ved. *marút-,* see EWAia II.322 s.v.).

acrostatic noun **mór-i-/*mér-i-* 'youth' (perhaps originally abstract, then concretized, as with Eng. *youth*), whence a derived adjective **mer-i̯-o-*, based (as expected) on the weak stem. For Latin: just as with *mare* 'sea', we may assume a neo-proterokinetic oblique (gen. **mr̥(r)-éi̯-s* → ** mr̥(r)-és*, etc.), whence a remodeled *i*-stem **mar-i-*, with *a*-vocalism.

It now becomes possible, on this basis, to provide an explicit account of the morphology and semantics of Lat. *marītus*. Most straightforwardly, one can begin with the neo-proterokinetic instrumental singular **mr̥(r)-i-h$_1$* > **marī* 'with a youth' (of the "super zero grade" type that is well-established for proterokinetic inflection, cf. Ved. *ūtī́* 'with help' < **h$_2$uH-ti-h$_1$*). A standard adjectivization of this form would then be the deinstrumental adjective **marī-to-* '[characterized by being] with a youth' ~ 'accompanied by a youth, married'.[18] Alternatively, it may be worth considering a basis in a dual **mér-i-h$_1$* 'two youths' (= 'young couple'), remodeled as **marī*, whence a derived adjective **marī-to-* 'pertaining to a young couple', i.e. 'married, wedded' (with the masculine substantivized in the sense 'husband').[19] For both of these alternatives, which begin from adjectival formations: note that the adjectival use of *marītus* is at least as old as the substantive (cf. 'wedded' = 'grafted, tied together', Cato *Ag.*).[20]

2.3. Lat. *monīle* 'necklace', *Manlius/Mallius* (PN)

It is convenient at this point to take up Lat. *monīle* 'necklace' [Afran.+], an evident counterexample to the proposed PIE **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/ process.[21] (For the original *o*-vocalism, cf. OIr. *muin* 'upper part of the back below the neck' and other Celtic material pointing to **moni-*, as well as OHG

[18] On Latin deinstrumental adjectives in *-ītus*, see Weiss 2009:293. As Norbert Oettinger points out to me (p.c.), it may even be possible, in view of the profusion of primary derivatives referring to females (in fact the majority, apart from Indo-Iranian), to begin from a sense 'young girl' rather than 'young man', whence *marītus* 'with a young girl/bride'.

[19] For other possible traces of the PIE dual in Latin, see Weiss 2009:195 with n. 9.

[20] OLat. MAREITVM in the "Claudia epitaph" (CIL I^2 1211, line 4; no earlier than about 125 BC, see Courtney 1995:235) is too late to disconfirm analyses like those just proposed based on **-iH + -to-*.

[21] Other counterexamples will be treated below, in **3**.

mana ‘mane’, OCS *monisto* ‘necklace’). Schrijver (1991:473) has offered two methods of explaining away the form, but both must be judged unconvincing.

According to the first proposal, the basis of *monīle* is actually **monH-i-*, cf. Skt *maṇí-* ‘id.’ (without Brugmann’s Law, cf. Av. *zarənu-maini-* ‘with a golden neck ornament’); since **mo-* > /ma-/ is restricted to application in open syllables (apart from a single and highly constrained closed-syllable environment [**4.** below]), such a sequence would be unaffected by the process, and *o*-vocalism would remain. But this cannot be accepted: even if the root actually contains a final laryngeal (see below for an alternative conception of the Indo-Iranian short-vowel forms), there is no other evidence (similarly de Vaan [2008:7]: “no certain evidence”) to support the idea that a prevocalic laryngeal would have survived long enough into Italic to block the application of this rule.

According to Schrijver’s second proposal (this one followed by de Vaan 2008:388, s.v.), the basis of *monīle* is actually **mon-i̯-o-* (i.e., a thematized *i*-stem **mon-i-*), which would again provide a closed syllable that would block the application of PIE **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/; a further derivation **moni̯e-li-* would then yield *monīli-*. But this is likewise unacceptable, this time for a series of morphological reasons. In general, to begin with, Latin does not thematize *i*-stems — for derived adjectives, cf. rather the types *cīvīlis*, *cīvicus* ← *cīvis* ‘citizen’, *marīnus*, *maritimus* ← *mare* ‘sea’. Nor, even assuming such a thematized **moni̯o-* or **moni̯e-*, can one justify a functionally redundant re-adjectivization with simplex *-li-* (this being, in any case, an otherwise unexampled derivational pattern).[22]

An interesting new datum connected with *monīle* is the name *Manlius/Mallius*, best known as the family name of a series of ancient Roman politicians and military leaders with the cognomen *Torquātus* (cf. *torques* ‘necklace’). According to an attractive proposal by Haudry (2002:10f., 14f., 101f.), the basis of this name (fitted out with standard gentilicium suffixation **-(i)i̯o-*) could be a form **man-li-,* itself syncopated from earlier **mani-li-*; this, in turn, would be related to an original *i*-stem **món-i-,* with the *a*-vocalism ultimately derived from zero-grade oblique

[22] Lat. *-īlis* adjectives based on thematic forms typically have a plain thematic noun as base (*erīlis* ← *erus* ‘master’, *servīlis* ← *servus* ‘slave’, etc.).

forms (Haudry himself sets up an oblique stem "**mn-éi̯-*" [2002:14]). Thus Lat. *monīle* (the substantivized neuter of an adjective **monīlis* ← **mon-i-* 'neck', cf. *cīvīlis* above), beside **mani-li-* in *Manlius/Mallius,* may point to another acrostatic *i*-stem **món-i-/*mén-i-* (and for the weak stem, cf. IIr. **mani-*, without Brugmann's Law). Again, a neo-proterokinetic oblique stem with zero grade will yield prevocalic forms with *a*-vocalism (gen. **mn̥(n)-éi̯-s* → **mn̥(n)-és*, etc., whence generalized oblique stem **man-i-*), just as with *mare* and *marītus.*[23] If Haudry's analysis is correct, however, we would have here **moni-* (from the old strong stem) and **mani-* (from the remodeled oblique stem) both preserved, while the generalization of the oblique stem in *mare* and *marītus* has ousted all trace in Italic of the original strong stem.

2.4. Lat. *manus*, U. **manuve** (loc. sg. + *-en*), SPi. **manus** (abl. pl.) 'hand', etc.

For Lat. *manus* (f.) 'hand' [XII Tab., Liv. Andr.+], Schrijver (1991:458) compares OIr. *muin* (< **mon-i-*) 'patronage, protection', which allows him to posit an *o*-grade source as input for the **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/ process. Some of the difficulties with this conception are registered by de Vaan (2008: 363f., s.v.), beginning with doubts about the Celtic comparison on semantic grounds.[24] The Celtic situation, where a meaning 'hand' is nowhere to be found, differs markedly from that of Gmc. **mundō* (more on which below), where a meaning 'protection' is found beside more widespread attestation of the meaning 'hand' (thus OIc./OS/OE *mund,* OHG *munt* f. 'hand', but OE also 'protection, guardianship'). Equally important, as de Vaan also notes, are questions about the morphological background of

[23] Haudry attempts to include *(Iūnō) Monēta* and *monēdula* 'jackdaw', but the background of these forms is highly uncertain. (For an entirely different view of *Monēta*, see recently Vennemann 2008.)

[24] The semantic complexity of the Celtic material surrounding OIr. *muin* is highlighted by Vendryes (LÉIA M-72f.), and the connection with Lat. *manus* is rejected by Matasović (2009:277), though partly, it must be admitted, on illegitimate grounds. (Matasović prefers connection with Gk. μάρη 'hand', but this cannot be correct; see Beekes 2010:905, s.v.)

Schrijver's presumed **mon-u-*, whether on its own terms or vis-à-vis Celt. **mon-i-*.

In considering the *a*-vocalism (as well as the morphology) of Lat. *manus* (and its Italic cognates), it is important to recall that Italic also displays clear traces of a plain consonant stem **man-* — in other words, an apparent root noun — restricted to usage as the first member of compounds. To be sure, some instances of this surface /man-/ can result from earlier **manu-* by syncope, or could have been modeled secondarily on **ped-* 'foot';[25] and as Klingenschmitt has shown (1992:111), U. **manf** (acc. pl., with consonant-stem inflection) is likely to have a secondary origin of some kind. Nevertheless, other forms are not likely to have such backgrounds, as in Lat. *mantēlum* 'hand-towel' (**man-tergslo-*),[26] O. (perf.) **manafum** (**man-fe-f-*) 'I have handed over' ~ Lat. *mandāre* 'hand over, entrust', among others.[27] The closest comparandum to this isolated Italic consonant stem **man-* is Gmc. **mundō* (< **mn̥-t(-)éh₂*) 'hand' (OIc. *mund,* etc.; see above), plausibly a derivative of a root noun.[28] Both Lat. *man-* and Gmc. **mun-,* then, can be traced to the oblique stem of a root noun, whether an *e/zero* type **men-/*mn̥-*, or perhaps rather (especially if one assigns Celt. **mon-i-* to this material) an acrostatic **món-/*mén-* (of the type **dóm-/*dém-* 'house'), where the oblique stem would be susceptible to replacement by a zero grade (cf. **dm̥(m)-és* → Arm. [gen. sg.] *tan*). Thus, once again, prevocalic oblique forms **mn̥(n)-és, *mn̥(n)-éi̯*, etc. would

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25 See Klingenschmitt 1992:111 n. 41 on Lat. *manceps* 'contractor' (perhaps < **manu-kap-*) and *malluviae* 'hand-washing water' (cf. *pelluviae* 'foot-washing water').

26 With a similar formation in U. **mantra(h)klu**/*mandraclo* (details in Untermann 2000:451).

27 Note also the adverbial forms Lat. *comminus* 'hand to hand', *ēminus* 'at a distance': if (as assumed by Ernout-Meillet, s.v. *manus*) these are in fact frozen nom. sg. masc. forms based on a thematic adjective (**-man-o-*), they would again point to consonant-stem **man-*.

28 Thus Neri (forthcoming), positing **men-/*mn̥-* 'Hervorragendes, Spitze' > 'Hand' (to **men-* 'project, jut out') as one possibility.

develop regularly to **man-es*, **man-eį*, etc., whence (at least) the Italic consonant stem surviving as *man-* in compound formations.[29]

The difficult problem remains of how best to account for the *u*-stem in Ital. **manu-* 'hand'. There are in fact several options; these can only be sketched here, but the essential point for present purposes is that they generally incorporate the possibility of a zero-grade stem with prevocalic **mn̥(n)-V*. From a descriptive point of view, Ital. **man-* ~ **man-u-* recalls well-known instances in which a root noun displays parallel *u*-stem forms, including **dom-* 'house' ~ **dom-u-* (with *u*-stem forms in Slavic, Indic, Greek, and Armenian)[30] and **neḱ-* 'death' ~ **neḱ-(o)u̯-* (with *u*-stem forms in Iranian, Greek, and Celtic).[31] Essentially the same pattern also emerges with the words for 'jaw', 'cheek', and 'chin',[32] which may involve at least one basic acrostatic source and an internally-derived feminine proterokinetic *u*-stem — one may thus consider possibilities for a similar background for (e.g.) **món-/*mén-* (→ **mn̥-*) or **mén-/*mn̥-* ~ (f.) **mén-u-/ *mn̥-éu̯-*. There is also the possibility (suggested by Neri [forthcoming]) that the *u*-stem inflection of Ital. **man-u-* arose from an old "*u*-locative" **mn̥(n)-éu̯*, where again the crucial basis would be the oblique zero-grade stem of a root noun.

2.5. Lat. *manēre* 'remain'

It is universally agreed that Lat. *manēre* 'remain' is fundamentally a stative in **-eh₁-*, which should therefore have an "ideal" shape **mn-eh₁-*, with zero-grade of the root; but there is no agreement on the source of the

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29 Given the Sabellic forms of this type (U. **mantra(h)klu**/*mandraclo,* O. **manafum**, etc.), the treatment in question can be assigned to Proto-Italic.

30 Lat. *u*-stem *domus* is often placed here, but see Weiss 2009:252f. for arguments favoring the independence of Lat. *domu-* from the other *u*-stem material (OCS *domŭ* [gen. sg. *domu,* etc.] 'house', Ved. *dámūnas-* 'belonging to the house', Gk. δμώς 'slave', Arm. *tanowtēr* 'house-lord').

31 Av. (acc.) *nasāum* 'corpse', Gk. νέκυς 'id.', W. *angheu* (cf. OIr. *écai*) 'death'. On this material, see in detail Nussbaum 2000.

32 Lat. *genae* 'cheeks' beside *genuīnī dentēs* 'molars'; Gk. γνάθος/γναθμός, Li. *žándas*, Maced. κάναδοι 'jaw' beside Ved. *hánu-*, Gk. γένυς 'jaw', Go. *kinnus* 'chin', etc.; see the detailed treatment by Nikolaev 2010:1-18.

a-vocalism.[33] According to Schrijver (1991:457f., crediting Beekes for the idea), *manēre* results from a contamination of an *o*-grade perfect and a stative, whence a hypothetical **mon-eh$_1$-*, which would undergo the **mo- > /ma-/ process. In the absence of any trace of such a perfect to this root in Latin (or, for that matter, anywhere else),[34] this is a highly implausible account, and is rejected even by de Vaan (2008:362, s.v.). De Vaan's own solution, however, is hardly an improvement: he posits, as input for the **mo- > /ma-/ rule, a regular development **mn-ē- > *monē-*; yet this is entirely ad hoc, and supported by no other evidence.

In contrast to these rather desperate approaches, it is attractive to view *manēre* as the result of a form **mn̥(n)-eh$_1$-*, with a secondarily syllabified prevocalic nasal; this will yield /manē-/ regularly, according to the treatment suggested by Nussbaum for such sequences, and thus exactly matches **mr̥(r)-éi̯-s* (whence *maris*), **mr̥(r)-i-h$_1$* (whence *marī(tus)*), **mn̥(n)-V́-* (whence *manus*, *man(tēlum)*, etc.).[35]

Descriptively, as already noted by Weiss (loc. cit. [n. 35]), this behavior (**mr̥(r)-éi̯-s* for **mr-éi̯-s*, etc.) recalls Lindeman's Law, certainly a valid comparison for those monosyllabic forms that have a chance of being old — thus also **mr̥(r)-i-h$_1$* for "ideal" **mr-i-h$_1$* (cf. *marītus*) and **mn̥(n)-V́-* for "ideal" **mn-V́-* (cf. *manus*, *mantēlum*, etc.). Note, however, that for *manēre*, this requires a starting point like monosyllabic **mneh$_1$t* 'was remaining', whence Lindeman variant **mn̥(n)ēt*; cf. Weiss' explicit suggestion that for this form, "[t]he Lindeman variant was imported from the imperfect/injunctive into the present" (2009:40). Yet as Jasanoff has shown (2002/3:147), stative presents like *manēre* may have been thematic (i.e., built with a sequence **-eh$_1$-i̯e/o-*) from the beginning. If so, the pre-Italic shape of such verbs would have been consistently polysyllabic (until the loss of intervocalic **-i̯-* and subsequent vowel contraction), in which

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[33] The essentially vacuous explanation in terms of a "secondary zero-grade" (cf. **2.1** above) continues to be popular: most recently Garnier 2010:422 ("néo-degré zéro"); similarly, though tentatively, LIV s.v. 2. **men-* ("Reduktionsstufe **m$_e$n-*?").

[34] Ved. (3 sg. pluperf.) *ámaman* is either a "Neubildung" or else belongs to **men-* 'think'; see LIV s.v. 2. **men-*.

[35] Similarly on **mn̥(n)-eh$_1$-* > /manē-/: Weiss 2009:40, 105; but see further below on some details of Weiss' analysis.

case the PIE version of "Lindeman's Law", in its classic formulation applying to monosyllables, cannot actually account for a new syllabification like **mn̥(n)ē-i̯e/o-*. There is, however, a series of other factors that may have come into play in cases of this kind:[36]

(i) Resyllabification can be related to constraints against certain initial clusters: thus [x]/mnV-/ is disallowed, but can be repaired by **mn̥(n)V-* > /manV-/.

(ii) Similarly, even for permitted initial clusters, inconvenient alternations arising from initial cluster treatments could have been removed, as a form of paradigmatic remodeling, by resyllabification: thus (given **mrV-* > Lat. *brV-*), a disfavored alternation like nom. sg. **mori*, gen. sg. [x]*bres* (< **mres* ← **mreis*) 'sea' could have been replaced by nom. **mori*, gen. **mr̥(r)es*.

(iii) Certain rhythmic tendencies in some morphological categories could have been highly favorable for the development of resyllabified forms, as with parisyllabic *i*-stems (thus disyllabic nom. **mori,* gen. **mr̥(r)es* favored over nom. **mori,* gen. [x]*bres*, even apart from the factor in (ii) just mentioned), or with highly-favored disyllabic stative stems (thus **mn̥(n)ē-*, **kl̥(l)-ē-*[37] like *timē-, horrē-, frīgē-, cluē-,* etc., as opposed to non-stative *-plēre* 'fill', *flēre* 'weep', not [x]*-palēre,* [x]*falēre*). In effect, this may amount to positing, for some categories, a late round of Lindeman-type resyllabifications for surviving monosyllabic forms, such as present stems that remained after *i̯*-loss, vowel contraction, and the apocope of final **-i*: e.g., from this perspective, **kl-eh$_1$-i̯e-ti* 'is warm' > **klēt* → **kl̥(l)ēt*.

Before turning to two final alleged open-syllable instances of the **mo-* > /ma-/ rule, it remains to comment on two additional points connected with the phonological treatment under discussion. The first concerns the restriction already noted above (**2.1**), i.e. that the treatment *R̥(R)V-* > /aRV-/ is operative for R = /r, l, n/ only. As I have argued elsewhere, the sequence **m̥(m)V-* instead develops regularly to /omV-/, as in Lat. *humī*

[36] The following survey is a sketch, sufficient for present purposes, of material to be explored in much more detail elsewhere.

[37] Here assuming (with LIV) aniṭ **ĥel-* for the root; but see Yamazaki 2009:451ff. for discussion of the problem.

'on the ground' and probably also *homō*, O. **humuns**, U. *homonus* 'human being' ~ Go. *guma* (Vine 1993:246ff., cf. Weiss 2009:105) or 1 pl. *sumus* 'we are' < **sm̥(m)os* (Weiss 2009:426), among other such forms.[38]

More broadly, the conception developed above — according to which *CR̥(R)V-* > /CaRV-/ not only for R = **r* and **l* (as generally assumed) but also for R = **n* — runs counter to a widely-held view according to which the phonologically regular outcome of prevocalic syllabic **n̥* is /en/, not /an/ (although this is sometimes specified only for syllabic **n̥* followed by laryngeal and vowel).[39] But there is nothing sacred about this claim. Of the two examples for **n̥HV* considered diagnostic by Schrijver (Lat. *sine* 'without', *tenuis* 'thin'),[40] both can readily be interpreted simply as *e*-grades.[41] Similarly, as for Lat. *tenēre* 'hold', which according to Meiser goes back to a stative **tn̥(n)-eh₁-i̯e/o-* (1998:65): this is contradicted by U. *tenitu* 'he shall hold' (VIb 25), which cannot continue a zero-grade and which (as pointed out by LIV, s.v. **ten-*) may well have taken its

38 See also Livingston 1997:43 on U. **sumel** 'at the same time'.

39 See in most detail Schrijver 1991:218-20 (specifying **CNHV* > **CeNV*, with the laryngeal still intact at this stage, given the identical treatment of the syllabic nasal before stops). Sihler (1995:98) considers the matter to be "disputed" (similarly Leumann 1977:59 ["nicht zuverlässig bestimmbar"]), but favors /enV/ as the outcome of **n̥(n)V*; and Meiser likewise gives /enV/ for both **n̥(n)V* (1998: 65) and **n̥HV* (1998:110). Somewhat apart stands the intriguing (though speculative) theory of Meiser (2003:186), according to which a series of Latin verbs with surface *d*-extension somehow arose as substitutes (with *-d-* as hiatus-breaker) for prevocalic (i.e., thematic) stems for verbs with root-final **-n̥(H)-* (e.g. **tn̥(n)-e/o-* > *tendere* 'extend', vs. expected [for Meiser] †*tenĕre*). Even if this conception should turn out to be accurate, it would apply to a restricted morphological context (and under special circumstances), rather than constituting a regular phonological treatment of sequences **-n̥(H)V-*.

40 Sihler cites only *tenuis,* Meiser cites only *tenuis* and *teneō* (on which see below).

41 Thus for *sine* < **seni* (so Weiss 2009:138), cf. perhaps Ved. *sanutár* 'away', GAv. *hanarə̄* (on *sine* and related forms, see recently Nikolaev 2010:275f., with earlier references); favoring *e*-grade **tenh₂u̯-i-* for *tenuis* e.g. Nussbaum 2004b (cf. also the detailed derivational picture incorporating the *e*-grade in Nikolaev 2010:213f.).

e-vocalism from the "Grundverb".[42] Finally, in view of what was said above about the treatment of **ɱ(m)V-*, there is no need to counter in detail the claimed development /emV/, which again rests on a slim number of equivocal cases.[43]

2.6. Lat. *malleus* 'hammer'

According to Schrijver (1991:455f., followed by de Vaan 2008:360), Lat. *malleus* 'hammer' [Pl.+] constitutes another example of the **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/ process. The proposed starting point is **molH-lo-* (to the 'grind' root, cf. Russ. *mólot* 'hammer'), this being an instrument noun in **-lo-* of the type *sella* 'seat' (< **sed-lā*). Laryngeal vocalization yields **mola-lo-*, and this produces **mala-lo-* by the rule in question. Then, an inner-Latin derivative **malaleo-* (for the formation, cf. **matea* 'hoe vel sim.', the basis of the diminutive *mateola* [2.7]) would undergo syncope, whence *malleo-*. There is, however, an immediate problem with the presumed starting point: a sequence **molH-lo-* should have undergone laryngeal loss by the "Saussure Effect" (Nussbaum 1997, Weiss 2009:113), yielding **mollo-* — thereby removing at least the open-syllable environment for the **mo-* > /ma-/ process.[44]

One can, of course, simply dismiss this analysis on the grounds that the background of the word is obscure. This, indeed, is the sentiment of Seldeslachts and Swiggers (1995:30 n. 42): "there is no sufficient evidence for a noun … **mallo-* < **malalo-*; the etymology of *malleus* … is too

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42 Note in particular the root aorist (cf. Ved. *átan*); on OLat. *tetinī* (beside *teneō*) as the regular replacement for a Pr.-Ital. root aorist, see Meiser 2003:192.

43 Diagnostic for Schrijver are *similis* 'alike' (for which an *e*-grade source is perfectly acceptable) and *gener* 'son-in-law' (which may even show preconsonantal **ɱ*; see de Vaan 2008:258 on aniṭ **gɱ-ro-*). As for *hemonem* (P.F. 89.8L), adduced by Schrijver (and routinely interpreted as *hemōnem*, although *hēmōnem* is also possible): this can be a genuine archaism with *e*-grade (probably delocatival, cf. Ved. *kṣámi*; Vine 1993:244, following Nussbaum 1986:187ff.), or could even have been created secondarily within Latin on the basis of *nēmō* (Livingston 1997:43ff.).

44 As we will see below, it is doubtful that the closed syllable /mol-/ would have undergone the **mo-* > /ma-/ unrounding.

uncertain to support such a reconstruction".[45] Nevertheless, it is possible to propose an alternative account. To begin with, one should reckon with the likelihood that so-called "instrument nouns in *-*lo*-" are largely (perhaps even entirely) a secondary development, based on verbal adjectives in *-*lo*-.[46] Thus, a possible starting point would be an archaic verbal adjective *$m\acute{l}h_2$-*ló*- 'grinding, crushing', which, if it had survived in Latin as such, would have produced an adjective ^{x}*blālo*-. An early substantivization *$m\acute{l}h_2$-*lo*-, with agentive sense nominalized as an instrument noun ('crusher' = 'the thing for crushing') and with the accent retraction typical of such substantivizations, would regularly yield **mala-lo*- (cf. *palma* 'flat [of the hand, foot]' < **pala-mā* < *$p\acute{l}h_2$-*meh*$_2$ ← *$pl̥h_2$-*méh*$_2$ 'flat'; Meiser 1998:109, Weiss 2009:110).[47] Then, just as with the final (pre-syncope) stage of Schrijver's analysis, **malalo*- could have been remodeled to **malale(i̯)o*-: compare not only **matea* (already cited), but a series of other tool or implement nouns with this format (*balteus* 'belt', *clipeus* 'shield', and others).[48]

As already seen by Schrijver, however, *malleus* cannot be separated from a parallel diminutive (or pseudo-diminutive) *marculus* 'mallet', to which we return below (**4.3**), in a discussion of the alleged unrounding process in initial closed syllables.

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45 For similar reasons (indeed, *a fortiori*), I leave out of account Lat. *malus* 'bad' (cf. Schrijver 1991:457 on the etymological difficulty).

46 See on this point Nielsen 2004. On the morphosyntax of PIE *-*lo*- (basically agentive), see Hackstein 2003.

47 Note that essentially the same derivational pattern, involving verbal adjectives in *-*lo*- (typically agentive) and instrument noun substantivizations, became productive in Latin at a later stage (i.e., based on synchronic verb roots): see Weiss 2009:279f. (agentive *crēdulus* 'believing', *tremulus* 'trembling', etc.; instrumental substantivizations *capulus* 'hilt', *iaculum* 'throwing-spear', etc.).

48 The "Leiden School", to be sure, is generally inimical to the "*palma* treatment" (see, e.g., Schrijver 1991:205ff. and de Vaan 2008 passim [s.vv. *calamitās, calvus, palma, salvus,* etc.]); but that is a larger issue that cannot be pursued here. (See for the moment Klingenschmitt 1992:95 n. 12, Rix 1996:157f.)

2.7 Lat. *mateola* 'mallet (vel sim.)'

The meaning of Lat. *mateola* [Cato+] (cited above, **2.6**) is not entirely clear, but seems to refer to a mallet or club of some kind. It is apparently a diminutive, based on a **matea,* for which a meaning like 'hoe' (or a similar implement) would be appropriate, in view of cognates like Skt. *matī-kar* 'to harrow, level the earth' (cf. Ved. *matiyá-* 'club, harrow'), OCS *motyka* 'hoe' (Russ. *motýga*), OHG *medela* 'plough', as well as the probable relationship with Lat. *metere* 'reap, harvest' (verbal noun *messis* 'reaping, crop'). Schrijver admits (1991:460) that "[a]s a technical term, the word could easily have been borrowed, which would invalidate it as evidence" for the rule in question. Nevertheless, a reconstruction with **mot-* is clearly admissible, and is judged possible by de Vaan (2008:367).

This is not, however, a compelling case, even apart from the possibility of borrowing (and also, as Schrijver notes, apart from uncertainty about the original vocalism: **o* or **a* in Balto-Slavic, **e* in Germanic, and either one in Indic, depending on one's views about the formulation of Brugmann's Law). On the basis of both the Indic material and the formation of Lat. **matea* (conceivably from a **mat-eu̯-ā*), it is reasonable to assume an *i*-stem basis **mot-i-* or **met-i-*.[49] Now in fact, the verbal root in Lat. *metere* is perhaps to be conceived of as **h₂met-*, cf. **h₂meh₁-* in Gmc. 'mow' (OHG *māen,* etc.) and Gk. ἀμάω 'id.'.[50] Whichever type of *i*-stem paradigm one chooses as a starting point (the two unmarked options being acrostatic **h₂mót-i-/*h₂mét-i-* or proterokinetic **h₂mét-i-/*h₂m̥t-éu̯-*), it is possible to arrive at a weak stem **h₂m̥t-éu̯-* as the basis for the thematization that would have resulted in Lat. **matea.*[51] If one assumes that Rix's

[49] So also de Vaan, tentatively: "PIE **mot-(i-*?) 'club, hoe'" (2008:366).

[50] Along these lines Ernout-Meillet (s.v. *metō*); more recent discussion in Schrijver 1991:20 and (with further references) de Vaan 2008:378. For present purposes, it is immaterial whether one operates with parallel enlarged forms **h₂m-eh₁-* ~ **h₂m-et-* (cf. **dr-eh₂-* ~ **dr-em-* 'sleep'), or on the basis of descriptively real (if still poorly understood) alternations of the sort **meh₁-* ~ **med-* 'measure', **gʷeh₂-* ~ **gʷem-* 'come; step', etc.

[51] For that matter, amphikinetic and hysterokinetic *i*-stems would also have produced allomorphs with zero grade of the root (obl. **h₂m̥t-i-́*).

Law operated in Italic,[52] the immediate phonologically regular outcome would have been *amteį- (ultimately assimilated to *anteį-); but this might inevitably have been remodeled to *mateį-, after Ital. *met-e/o- (> Lat. *metere*).

3. Additional counterexamples to PIE *mo- > Ital. /ma-/[53]

3.1. The *o*-vocalism of Lat. *monēre* 'warn' is an evident surface violation of the *mo- > /ma-/ process. But as Schrijver suggests (1991:472), this could be nothing more than a trivial restoration on the model of other *o*-grade causatives, a development that would also confer the benefit of maintaining a formal distinction between this verb and *manēre* 'remain'. All this is perfectly reasonable and may be granted;[54] but other counterexamples pose more serious difficulties.

3.2. Lat. *mola* 'millstone; ground barley' [Naev.+] (: *$melh_2$- 'grind') descends from a laryngeal-final root; therefore, Schrijver offers (1991:473) a "laryngeal defense" for the non-application of *mo- > Ital. /ma-/, exactly comparable to that proposed for *monīle* (**2.3**). But for the reasons already mentioned in connection with *monīle*, this approach must be rejected for *mola*, too.[55] Likewise unattractive is de Vaan's alternative suggestion (2008:387, s.v. *molō*) that *mola* was formed at the stage when Pr.-Ital. **melati* had given VOLat.[56] **molati*, with rounded vowel preceding the velar *l*. Apart from the minor point that apocope of final *-i* had already taken

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52 A strong possibility, though not without controversy; for recent discussion, see Weiss 2009:172 n. 21.

53 I.e., in addition to the counterexample *monīle* (**2.3** above).

54 So also Rasmussen 1993:201 (*moneō* "obviously with restored *o* due to the causative function").

55 So also (for both *mola* and *mora* [**3.3**]) Seldeslachts and Swiggers 1995:30 n. 37 ("we find it very hard to believe that laryngeals had been maintained for so long as Schrijver is ready to accept").

56 "VOLat." = Very Old Latin (the era of the oldest non-literary texts, approximately 7th c. to 240 BC), cf. de Vaan 2008:14, Weiss 2009:23.

place at this stage,[57] the more salient issue is the unlikelihood that light and dark *l* had already exerted their effects on preceding vowels: cf. HAVELOD (Forum Inscription, CIL I^2 1; 7th/6th c. BC). In that case, the formation of *mola* (according to this proposal) would have to be placed at a relatively late date — not at all an attractive assumption for a word that appears to be an archaic *o*-grade "τομή form" (rare and unproductive in Latin) of the type *rota* 'wheel', *toga* 'covering' (cf. Weiss 2009:300, and *mora* in **3.3**).

3.3. For *mora* 'delay' [Plt.+], Schrijver again mounts a "laryngeal defense" for the non-application of **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/ (1991:110, 216, 473), positing a τομή form **morH-eh$_2$,* with the root-final laryngeal assumed on the basis of OIr. *maraid* 'remains'. Even if this is the correct root structure, which is eminently possible,[58] the appeal to the PIE root structure is as invalid here as for *monīle* and *mola* above. De Vaan (2008:388f.) offers the alternative suggestion that Lat. *morārī* (OLat. also *morāre*) 'delay' might be an old iterative **morH-éi̯e/o-* (with *mora* in that case post-verbal), rather than being denominative to *mora,* as is usually assumed. If so, as perhaps with the causative *monēre* (**3.1**), *o*-vocalism could have been restored in the iterative. But as pointed out by Schumacher (2004:476), the assumption of an iterative would be compelling only if the *to*-participle of *morārī* had the shape †*moritus,* which is nowhere attested; thus *morātus* points rather in the direction of the traditional interpretation of the verb as denominative to *mora.*[59]

3.4. A "laryngeal defense" is clearly not available for *modus* 'measure, manner' (: **med-* 'measure'). Here Schrijver assumes (1991:466ff., cf. de Vaan 2008:384f.) that the starting point was a thematic **med-o-* (beside *s*-stem **med-es-*, cf. the derived adjectives in U. *mersto* ~ Lat. *modestus,*

[57] Thus the form at issue would be **molat*, not **molati*; cf., e.g., IOVESAT and MITAT (Duenos Inscription, CIL I^2 4; 6th c. BC).

[58] Note, however, the parenthetical notation "?**mer(H)-* preferred by LIV.

[59] I leave aside here the additional problem posed by an iterative **morH-éi̯e/o-*, which would have to be specified as **morh$_2$-éi̯e/o-* (as Schumacher points out). Whether or not it is legitimate to assume laryngeal coloring across the morpheme boundary in such formations constitutes a complex problem that need not engage us here.

U. **mersuva** < **medes-u̯o-*[60]); this **med-o-* then underwent a rounding rule **meCo-* > /moCo-/ within Latin — one subpart of a more general *o*-Umlaut rule — whence *modus*. This analysis, however, is problematic both phonologically and morphologically. The **meCo-* > /moCo-/ subpart, to begin with, is essentially ad hoc: Schrijver himself admits (1991:469) that for his preliminary formulation of the general *o*-Umlaut rule, *modus* constitutes "the only instance of rounding after *m*-". Although he does go on to invoke the process also for *molestus* (see **3.5**), it has virtually no other support, apart from the equivocal perfect stem *momordī* (to *mordēre* 'bite'), for which *memordī* is also attested.[61] On the morphological side: whereas **mod-o-* would be an unremarkable "τόμος form" (a well-represented category in Latin, as elsewhere), it is distinctly unattractive to posit a **med-o-*, belonging to a rare and still poorly-understood *e*-grade thematic type — nor, in fact, is there any direct evidence for such a form. As de Vaan points out, the first member of the compound seen in O. **meddíss** (and related forms referring to the public official "meddix") might well contain a root noun **med-* (rather than a syncopated **medo-*); and the **medos* of U. **meřs**/*mers* 'law' (nom. sg., exclusively in fixed collocations with the verb 'be': e.g., **meřs est** 'it is the law', Ib 18 [bis]) is far more likely the nom. sg. of the otherwise attested *s*-stem **med-es-* (as is usually assumed; see Untermann 2000:462) than the nom. sg. of an alleged (and otherwise unattested) thematic **med-o-*. There is, finally, no difficulty with the traditional account of Lat. *modestus*, according to which its *o*-vocalism (vs. U. *mersto*) is owed to influence from thematic **mod-o-*, just as in *pondus, -eris* 'weight' (cf. *ponderāre* 'weigh') beside *o*-stem **pond-o-* in OLat. *pondō* 'by weight'.

3.5. As just mentioned, the same **meCo-* > /moCo-/ subrule is used to explain away *molestus* 'irksome' (Schrijver 1991:469f., de Vaan 2008:386). Here, the presumed starting point in a theoretical *s*-stem **mel-es-* is morphologically in order; but there is in principle no reason why the *o*-vocalism cannot result from a pattern like that just seen in *modestus*. A parallel

[60] For various details concerning the phonological interpretation of U. **mersuva**, see Weiss 2010:99 n. 4.

[61] On the better-founded Latin *e* > *o* rules, see Weiss 2009:138f.

o-grade form, while not attested within Italic, might be found in the isolated adverb Gk. μόλις 'scarcely, with difficulty' [Aesch.+], hitherto obscure[62] but plausibly relatable morphologically to Lat. *mōlēs* 'mass', given (a) the possibility that μόλις is a frozen nom. sg. of an *i*-stem (Schwyzer 1939:620), and (b) Schaffner's attractive proposal (2006:23) that *mōlēs* is fundamentally a hysterokinetic *i*-stem (whence denominative *mōlīrī* 'strive, toil').[63]

3.6. To summarize briefly: even if a natural explanation can account for the *o*-vocalism of *monēre* (**3.1**), the other counterexamples (*monīle, mola, mora, modus, molestus*) weigh strongly against the **mo-* > /ma-/ theory, in the absence of convincing rationales for the *o*-vocalism in these forms.

4. PIE **mo-* > Ital. **ma-* in initial closed syllables

For initial closed syllables, Schrijver offers two instances of **mo-* > /ma-/ unrounding, in both cases in the restricted environment before /r/ and a following velar stop. Both seem appealing at first sight, and on phonetic grounds, the pre-rhotic environment is certainly favorable to vowel lowering, both typologically and with regard to Latin itself.[64] Questions remain, however, about both cases.

4.1. Lat. *marcēre* 'droop, be weak'

Lat. *marcēre* 'droop, be weak' [*permarcēre* Enn. *Ann.* 548Sk], beside *marcidus* 'weak' [Ov.+], should reflect a stative **mr̥k-eh₁-* (cf. Ved. *mr̥c-* 'harm', *markā-* 'destruction', etc.); the resulting Italic **morkē-* would yield Lat. *marcē-* by the unrounding rule (Schrijver 1991:458f.). This account of the *a*-vocalism, however, is not secure: Meiser (1998:84f.) registers skepticism (followed by de Vaan 2008:364) on the basis of Lat. *murcidus* 'slothful' (Pompon.+), which would seem to derive from a **mork-*,

62 Beekes (2010:963, s.v.): "No etymology".

63 I hope to explore this material in more detail elsewhere.

64 Within Latin, compare the regular lowering of high vowels before /r/ in non-initial open syllables (Weiss 2009:117).

without the unrounding effect.[65] It may also be necessary to reckon with Lat. *murcus* [Amm.+] '(self-mutilating) malingerer': although often regarded as back-formed to *murcidus* (so Leumann 1977:329), the form is "sans doute ancien" (despite its late attestation), according to Ernout-Meillet (s.v.), who compare, perhaps correctly, the cognomen *Murcus* [Cic.+], and other possibly early onomastic versions of this word [Liv.+] designating the Aventine Hill and associated divinities (*dea Murcia,* etc.).[66]

4.2. Lat. *margō* 'border'

Lat. *margō* 'border' (gen. *marginis*) [Varro+] clearly belongs with Go. *marka-* 'border, area' (< PIE **morĝ-o-*)[67] and (descriptively with metathesis) OIr. *mruig* 'territory, area', cf. Gaul. *Allo-brog-es,* etc. (< Pr.-Celt. **mrog-i-*); thus Ital. **morg-ōn-* can develop to Lat. *margō* by the restricted version of the unrounding rule under discussion (Schrijver 1991:465). But as de Vaan points out (2008:365), the *n*-stem inflection leaves open the alternative possibility that the *a*-vocalism could result from a regular vocalization of the zero-grade sequence **mr̥g-n-* (i.e., applying the process mentioned in **1.2** above, *R̥DC > RaDC*).[68]

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[65] De Vaan (loc. cit.) also adduces *muricidus* [sic] 'faint-hearted' [Pl. *Ep.* 333, cited at P.F. 112.18L], in case the word is "maybe a corruption of *murcidus*". But this is unlikely to be correct: the form (an absolute hapax, voc. sg. in context) scans *mūricīde* (cf. *murri-* in the Festus manuscripts), whether the verse is a trochaic septenarius (as transmitted) or an iambic octonarius (as with the emended version offered by Lindsay, in his OCT apparatus ad loc.); *murcide* here is merely an old conjecture (Lambinus, after Hermolaus), which in fact produces an inferior metrical scheme for the passage (see Leo's apparatus, ad loc.).

[66] Note especially P.F. 135.15L (*Murciae deae* sacellum erat sub monte Aventino, qui antea Murcus vocabatur).

[67] The palatal is reconstructed on the basis of Pers. *marz* 'region'.

[68] Differently Rix (1996:161), opting for a "secondary zero grade" explanation for the *a*-vocalism in forms like *marcēre* and *margō.*

4.3. Lat. *marculus* ‘mallet’

According to an analysis by Seldeslachts and Swiggers (1995:28ff.), Lat. *marculus* ‘mallet’ [Lucil.+] (already alluded to above, 2.6) could go back to an instrument noun **molH-tlo-* (to the ‘grind’ root; cf. again Russ. *mólot* ‘hammer’).[69] After “Saussure Effect” laryngeal deletion, the resulting **moltlo-* would develop regularly to **molklo-*; a dissimilated **morklo-* could then undergo the unrounding rule, whence **marklo-* and (with regular anaptyxis) *marculus.* (The resulting form is thus only artificially diminutive in form.) This account is rightly favored by de Vaan (2008:360) over Schrijver’s much more “cumbersome” versions, operating with various diminutive formations.[70] De Vaan points out, however, that **molklo-* could simply have been remodeled to **malklo-* after the **mal-* of *malleus*, in which case *marculus* would have no bearing on the unrounding rule.

4.4. The restricted environment as specified by Schrijver (**morK-* > /marK-/) seems clearly to be required: no such process operates with **l* (cf. *mulcēre* ‘stroke’, among other such forms) or, apparently, with non-velars (cf. *mordēre* ‘bite’, *morbus* ‘sickness’, among other such forms). Nevertheless, as Katz has discussed (2006:338ff.), a case can be made that Lat. *masturbārī* ‘masturbate’, which in his view (following Watkins 1995:535) is based on a word **mostr̥g^{h}-* ‘marrow’,[71] may justify a process **most-* > /mast-/, or even (more generally) **mosC-* > /masC-/. As Katz shows (2006:340 n. 50), there are no genuine Latin words in /most-/, and therefore no counterexamples. It is less clear than for **morK-,* however, how the phonetics of **most-* or **mosC-* might correlate with the **o* > /a/ development here.

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69 On the secondary forms *martulus, martellus* see Seldeslachts and Swiggers 1995:29 with n. 32.

70 See Schrijver 1991:456f. and de Vaan loc. cit. for details, as well as Seldeslachts and Swiggers 1995:30 n. 42.

71 Cf. especially Skt. *mastr̥han-*, Av. *mastərəγan-* ‘brain’.

5. Conclusions

De Vaan (2008:366, s.v. *māsˑ*) voices an explicit preference for restricting Schrijver's PIE **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/ rule to operation in initial open syllables, given the difficulties and alternative possibilities for *marcēre* (**4.1**) and *margō* (**4.2**). In brief conclusion: I have tried to show that the situation may be just the reverse — PIE **mo-* > Ital. /ma-/ holds out some promise for restricted types of closed initial syllables; in contrast, the rule should be rejected for initial open syllables, given a significant number of weighty counterexamples, along with more attractive methods of accounting for the *a*-vocalism of the forms in question.[72]

[72] An earlier version of this paper was presented at the 141st Meeting of the American Philological Association (Anaheim, CA; January 2010). I am grateful to the auditors on that occasion for their helpful comments, in particular Benjamin Fortson and Jeremy Rau.

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